A Corpus Feminist Critical Discourse Analysis of Nigerian Online News Reports on Human Trafficking

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Abstract
Studies on human trafficking are expanding in diverse disciplines; however, the representation of human trafficking in online news discourse is still under-explored in linguistic studies. This study thus applies corpus-assisted feminist critical discourse framework to explore the representation of human trafficking discourse in online news reports (2016-2022) in Nigeria; and analyse the ideological gendered structures implicit therein. Data comprise a specialised corpus of 216,459 words of news texts on human trafficking retrieved from the online news archives of selected frontline Nigerian newspapers. The study adopts a synergy of corpus linguistics (CL), discourse historical approach (DHA) and feminist critical discourse analysis (FCDA) as the theoretical base, while *Sketch Engine* is deployed as the corpus tool. Findings reveal four constructs set within a polarised discourse of ingroup versus outgroup structure: combative stance, girl-child prostitution and forced labour, parents' complicity and juju ritualism. Primary discursive strategies like perspectivisation, nomination, predication, etc., are amply deployed in the construction, while sub-strategies like collectivisation and descriptivisation also play complementary roles. Human traffickers are negatively represented as economic/sexual exploiters and voodooist, and trafficked-victims as naïve, economically disadvantaged and vulnerable individuals. The negative constructs portray the feminisation of human trafficking in which girls are commodified for sexual gratification, thus highlighting the crucial connection between gender and human trafficking discourse in Nigerian online news media. This study thus demonstrates the significant role of gender inequalities in the socio-cultural variables fuelling human trafficking in Nigeria.
Keywords: corpus, gender, human trafficking, online news reports, Nigeria

Introduction
Human trafficking, also known as trafficking in persons, is a networking process of recruiting persons from their local community or place of origin through coercion, abduction or deception, and transiting them to destinations, within or across national borders, where they are subjected to sexual exploitation, forced labour, organ harvesting or other forms of exploitative services (UN General Assembly, 2000; Goździak & Bump, 2008; Makisaka, 2009; U.S. Department of Education, Office of Safe and Supportive Schools, 2021). Trafficking-in-persons could occur within a community, state or country (domestic trafficking) or between two or more countries (transnational or cross-border trafficking) (Sweileh, 2018; Adeyeye & Egbulefu, 2022). With its supposed global pervasiveness and economic exploitation of the vulnerable, human trafficking has steadily become a seemingly structured cross-border criminal enterprise of huge concern not just(non) governmental agencies and activists, but also to scholars worldwide.

Consequently, discourses on human trafficking are increasingly growing in diverse disciplines as the issue gains more global concern.

Previous discourses have largely focused on its definitional nuances and complexities (Goździak & Collett, 2005), aetiologies (Vidushy, 2016), types (Shelley, 2010), prevalence (Feingold, 2005), regional patterns and trends (UNODC, 2021), trafficked victims' and traffickers' profiles (Wheeler, 2022) and traffickers' recruitment techniques (Izcara Palacios, 2020). In addition, studies exist on the gender dimensions of human trafficking (Papadopoulos, 2021), its health implications (Shin, Oberlin, Rigby & Chelmow, 2020), socio-economic impacts (Wheaton, Schauer & Galli, 2010) and legal consequences (Richard, 2005). Other studies have also explored media coverage of human trafficking (Sanford, Martínez & Weitzer, 2016), the role of the social media in human trafficking (Terwilliger, 2021), as well as the relation between human trafficking and sporting events (Bowersox, 2016), among others. However, despite these growing discourses on human trafficking, most extant studies are conducted in the fields of sociology, criminology, law, penology, medicine, public health, gender studies, migration studies and security studies.

In spite of this paucity, a few linguistic studies have explored human trafficking discourse from the theoretical paradigms of discourse analysis (Pacheco, 2020; Pinto, 2022), critical discourse analysis (Gregoriou & Ras, 2018; Gleason, Baker & Maynard, 2018) and ethnographic discourse analysis (Cox, 2015; Romig, 2017). Others have also examined it from the linguistic angles of content analysis (Gulati, 2011; Sanford, Martínez & Weitzer, 2016), sentiment analysis (Mensikova & Mattman, 2018) and corpus linguistics (Gregoriou & Ras, 2018; Muždeka, 2018; Osisanwo, 2024; Olajimbiti & Osisanwo, 2024). While a large number of these studies are theoretically hinged on critical discourse analytical approaches, a corpus feminist critical discourse analysis of human trafficking is rare in the literature. Although feminist discourses on human trafficking such as Lobasz (2009), Pourmokhtari (2015), Jones and Kingshott (2016) and Hogan (2021), among others, have examined the impacts of sexist/patriarchal stereotypes in the construction of trafficked victims and their traffickers, none of these studies, to the best of my knowledge, has feminist linguistic orientation. Most significantly, none of the studies is set within a corpus-oriented feminist critical discourse analytical framework. By implication, there is paucity of systematic corpus-based feminist linguistic exploration in human trafficking discourses which demonstrates that no concrete methodology nor empirical linguistic theory exists for the interpretation of gender-based issues in human trafficking discourses. Thus, this study addresses these research gaps by deploying a corpus feminist critical linguistic framework in exploring Nigerian online news reports on human trafficking.

The role of the news media, both print and electronic, in the reportage of human trafficking cases and in shaping public perception about the phenomenon has received increased attention across countries. Scholars have explored the coverage of human trafficking in the UK news media (Gregoriou & Ras, 2018; Muždeka, 2018), the US (Sanford, 2015; Sanford, Martínez & Weitzer, 2016), Germany (Küblbeck, 2019), India, Thailand and the USA (Sobel, 2014), Malaysia (Suppiah & Kaur, 2018), and Serbia (Muždeka, 2018), among others. In this growing literature, however, Nigerian news media coverage of human trafficking is sparsely studied. Only a limited number of

scholars such as Nkememena (2009), Olube (2015) and Adeyeye and Egbulefu (2022) have explored Nigerian media coverage of human trafficking. Nevertheless, their explorations have no linguistic orientation since none of their studies is hinged on corpus linguistics or feminist critical linguistic approaches.

To this end, the study seeks to examine the representation of human trafficking in Nigerian online news media by analysing a corpus of online news texts on human trafficking in Nigeria. The specific objectives of the study are to: a) examine how keywords collocate in the corpus to define human trafficking issues; b) explore dominant discursive strategies emanating from the keywords c) analyse the ideological gender structures implicit in the discursive strategies. With these objectives, the study hopes to enhance a better understanding of the relations between news media language, gender and socio-cultural values regarding human trafficking reportage in Nigeria.

Data, Methodology and Theory

Data for the study consist of a specialised corpus of Nigerian online news reports on human trafficking. The data corpus, which include news, opinions, features, editorials and interviews, comprise 216,459 words of written texts retrieved from the online news archives of six Nigerian newspapers, namely: *Premium Times Nigeria; Tribune Online; Punch Newspapers; Vanguard News; the Guardian Nigeria News;* and *Sahara Reporters*. These newspapers are notable for their constant and expansive reportage of human trafficking issues in Nigeria. Seventy (70) news reports on various issues on human trafficking covering a period of seven years, 2016-2022 (ten per year) were retrieved from the online news archives on human trafficking of each of the six newspapers through a purposive sampling technique to make a total of 420 news items. The chosen seven-year period reflects greater frequency rate of reportage of human trafficking issues in the chosen newspapers.

For the corpus analysis, the data were retrieved, copied, saved as Human Trafficking News Corpus using the MS Word, and imported into the corpus software for the statistical analysis. *Sketch Engine*, a corpus linguistic (CL) tool for analysing language data, comes in handy in tracing the concordance which tracks and displays the occurrences of keywords within their co-textual environments to enhance contextual interpretation. According to Osisanwo (2024, p. 5), these keywords are discrete words, phrases or tokens that are frequent in the corpus, and define the discursive "constructions around human trafficking." Inasmuch as corpus-assisted critical discourse analysis conflates methods in corpus linguistics with critical discourse studies (Partington, 2004, 2006; Baker et al., 2008), a corpus-based critical discourse analyst moves further to interpret the linguistic contents through one or more critical discourse approaches after sorting out linguistic patterns on a corpus via corpus methods.

This study orients to Reisigl and Wodak's (2009, p. 95) critical discourse-historical approach (DHA) which explores how social participants, objects/phenomena/events and processes/actions are discursively constructed, qualified, intensified or mitigated in text/talk; by so doing, positions and justifies writer's/speaker's point of view. In addressing these concerns, five salient discursive strategies characterise the framework – Nomination, Predication, Perspectivisation, Argumentation, and Intensification/ Mitigation (Reisigl & Wodak, 2009, p. 95; Olajimbiti & Osisanwo, 2024, p. 6).

Nomination focuses on the construction of social actors, ingroup/outgroup categorisation represented in discourse via the deployment of deitics, anthroponyms, metaphors, verbs, nouns and other referential devices. Predication deals with the use of positive or negative attributes to qualify social actors, objects, phenomena and actions represented in discourse. This is most achieved realised through stereotypical attributions, explicit predicative (pro)nouns, adjectives, metaphors or allusions. Perspectivisation expresses speaker's/writer's attitudinal positioning and involvement in the discourse through the use of (in) direct speech, quotation marks, discourse markers, etc. Such positionings express "involvement or distance as evident through the use of positive self-representation and negative Other-presentation" (Olajimbiti & Osisanwo, 2024, p. 6). Argumentation questions or justifies positive or negative attributes against their normative rightness using topoi (Reisigl & Wodak, 2009, p. 95). Intensification or mitigation upgrades or downgrades the illocutionary force as well as the epistemic/deontic status of utterances using verbs of feeling, saying and thinking (Olajimbiti & Osisanwo, 2024, p. 6).

The DHA was synergised with by Lazar's (2007) feminist critical discourse analytical perspective which constitutes a theory of action that deconstructs the nuanced, systemic and subtle operations of unequal power relations in discourse in the entrenchment of gender hegemony. The theory shows how gender, power relations and ideology intersect discursively to (re)produce, entrench, negotiate or resist all forms of gendered order for the sake of effecting a gender-balanced society. FCDA operates through five interconnected principles, namely: feminist analytical resistance; gender as ideological structure; the complexity of gender and power relations; discourse in the (de)construction of gender; and critical reflexivity. The synergy of the theories – corpus linguistics, DHA and FCDA – provides corpus-guided insights into the discursive and gender representations of human trafficking in Nigerian online news media. It must be noted that the current study bears some semblances with the works of Osisanwo (2024) and Olajimbiti and Osisanwo (2024) owing to their application of corpus linguistics and critical discourse analytical approaches in examining some corpora of social media posts on human trafficking and child trafficking, respectively. However, these studies circumvent feminist criticism and their corpora were chiefly social media posts. The exploration of Nigerian news media coverage of human trafficking from a corpus-based feminist critical linguistic perspective is the gap this study intends to fill. Hence, its uniqueness lies in the use of corpus of online news texts on human trafficking and its integration of a mixed method of CL, DHA and FCDA.

Analysis and Findings

This section has three layers: a) the corpus results; b) the discursive strategies of human trafficking construction in online news media representation; and the c) discussion of findings.

Corpus Results

Table 1 displays keywords in the corpus on human trafficking construction in Nigerian online news media. Keywords index the basic concepts, topics or thematic foci in a corpus

(Osisanwo, 2024). Owing to space, a list of 50 keywords is presented in Table I ranked in their order of keyness scores.

Item	Frequency (focus)	Frequency (reference)	Relative frequency (focus)	Relative frequency (reference)	Score
1. Naptip	912	859	3747.07251	0.01395	3696.51
2. Trafficking	2534	544338	10411.27441	8.83867	1058.3
3. Trafficker	599	95101	2461.0708	1.5442	967.72
4. Okah-donli	125	95	513.57904	0.00154	513.786
5. Nigerian	778	495987	3196.51587	8.05357	353.177
6. Persons	351	193757	1442.12988	3.14612	348.067
7. Abuja	171	77060	702.57611	1.25126	312.526
8. Prostitution	300	202647	1232.58972	3.29047	287.518
9. Benin	152	74330	624.51208	1.20693	283.431
10. Lagos	294	207335	1207.93787	3.36659	276.861
11. Traffick	89	20012	365.66827	0.32494	276.742
12. Nigeria	1091	974009	4482.51807	15.81543	266.631
13. Zonal	103	41167	423.18912	0.66845	254.242
14. Returnee	77	37788	316.36469	0.61358	196.683
15. Abia	53	16114	217.75751	0.26165	173.39
16. Nscdc	43	1724	176.67119	0.02799	172.833
17. Enuigu	58	24827	238.30067	0.40313	170.548
18. Director-general	87	79323	357.45102	1.288	156.665
19. Katsina	44	10648	180.77982	0.1729	154.984
20. Oyo	52	28362	213.64888	0.46053	146.967
21. Sensitisation	41	9424	168.45392	0.15302	146.965
22. Mali	120	156209	493.03586	2.53644	139.699
23. Unodc	48	26044	197.21434	0.42289	139.304
24. Anambra	46	23854	188.99709	0.38733	136.952
25. Asemota	33	343	135.58487	0.00557	135.828
26. Prohibition	278	471400	1142.19971	7.65434	132.096
27. Libya	236	409122	969.63721	6.6431	126.995
28. Ebonyi	34	7026	139.6935	0.11408	126.286
29. Anti-human	36	13293	147.91077	0.21584	122.475
30. Nwanwenne	29	19	119.15034	0.00031	120.113
31. Niger	101	155654	414.97186	2.52743	117.925
32. Ogun	35	19431	143.80212	0.31551	110.073
33. Anti-trafficking	32	15638	131.47623	0.25392	105.65
34. Osun	31	14098	127.3676	0.22892	104.456
35. Obaseki	27	4877	110.93307	0.07919	103.72
36. Emerole	25	50	102.71581	0.00081	103.632
37. Makurdi	26	2700	106.82444	0.04384	103.296
38. Ondo	30	15147	123.25896	0.24595	99.73
39. Brothel	55	83269	225.97478	1.35208	96.5
40. Burkina	47	64470	193.10571	1.04683	94.832
41. Madam	75	142795	308.14743	2.31863	93.155
42. Seme	23	6183	94.49854	0.1004	86.786
43. Naira	31	30668	127.3676	0.49797	85.694
44. Arraign	32	34547	131.47623	0.56096	84.869
45. Sensitise	25	14279	102.71581	0.23185	84.195
46. Ibadan	28	25631	115.0417	0.41618	81.94
47. Exploitation	190	527606	780.64014	8.56698	81.702
48. Indigene	22	8205	90.38991	0.13323	80.646
49. Ecowas	29	30897	119.15034	0.50169	80.01
50. Victim	1237	3855333	5082.37793	62.6008	79.926

Table 1: Keywords in the Corpus

In line with Osisanwo's (2024) submission, these keywords not only define trends in the corpus, they also mirror the focal points of Nigerian online news media outlets in their representation of human trafficking in the country. A close analysis of the keyword foci orients to three dominant major representations of human trafficking in Nigerian online news media: a) Combative Stance Representation; b) Prostitution/Sexual Exploitation; and c) Parents' Complicity.

To further reflect the corpus' discursive trajectory, a Word Cloud view of the second most frequent keyword "trafficking" is presented in Figure 1 to broadly capture how human trafficking is discursively constructed in the corpus. The graphics highlights the dominant lexemes that collocate with trafficking and maps out the constructions into three sub-representations:

a) representation of human trafficking as exploitation/slavery/crime/ prostitution/labour
b) representation of traffickers
c) representation of victims (girl, child, woman)

These sub-divisions upscale the dominance of negativities in Nigerian online news representation of human trafficking. Most importantly, the Word Cloud view unmasks the gender structure in the representation as only the female gender (girl and woman) appears as collocates of trafficking as demonstrated in Figure 1 below:

Figure 1: Word Cloud of Trafficking

The Concordance view in Figure 2 enhances our corpus findings by specifically identifying the major forms of trafficking represented in the corpus: human, sex, girl-child, young women, and child traffickings.

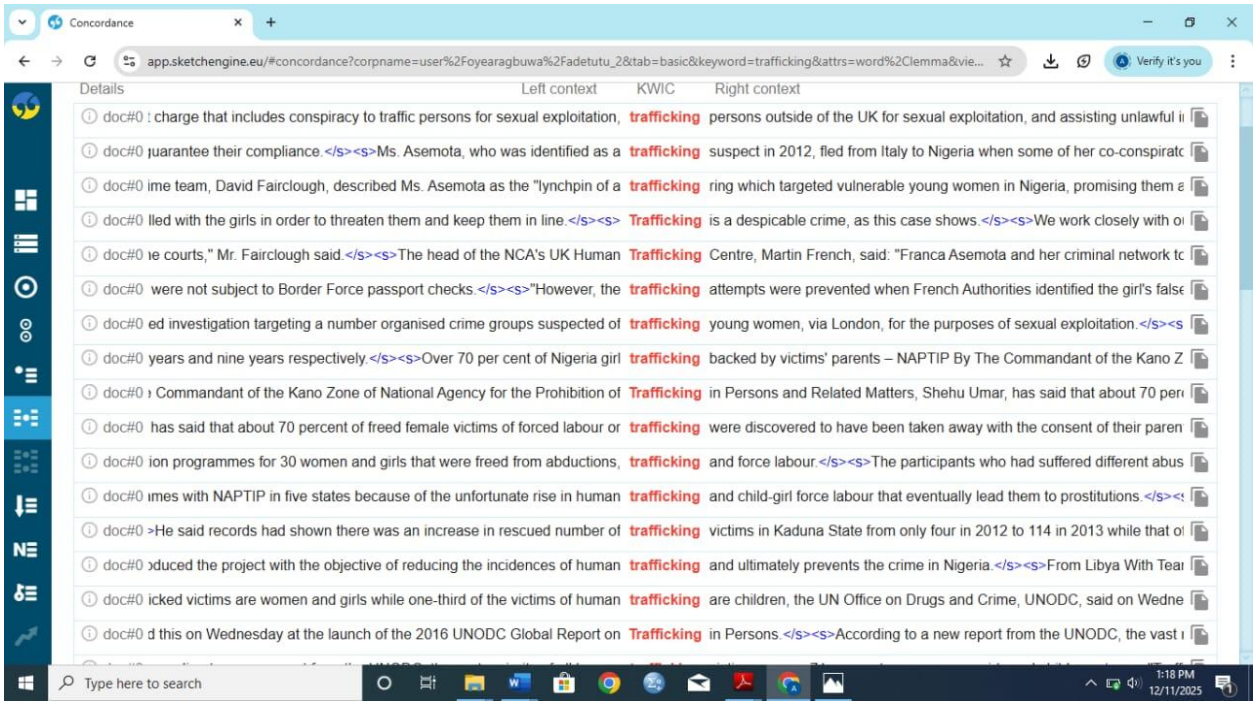

Figure 2: Concordance View of Trafficking

These represented forms further validate the heinousness of trafficking in Nigeria, the exploitative tendencies of traffickers and the vulnerability of trafficked victims. The

discursive representations portrayed in all the corpus findings are synergised into four dominant constructs outlined below:

a) Combative Stance Representation
b) Child-Girl Sexual Exploitation and Forced Labour
c) Parents' Complicity
d) Juju Ritualism in Trafficking

Discursive Strategies in the Representation of Human Trafficking

For ease of analysis, this section analyses each of the constructions above in order to explore the discursive strategies deployed in each.

Combative Stance Representation

The combative attitudinal stance of the Nigerian government against trafficking-in-persons is the most dominant construct in the corpus results. This significantly reflects in the topmost frequently featured keyword in the corpus – "NAPTIP", with a relative frequency of 3696.51. NAPTIP is an acronym which represents "The National Agency for the Prohibition of Traffic in Persons and Other Related Matters". It is a Nigerian federal agency that is responsible for preventing human trafficking in the country, prosecting traffickers and rescuing and rehabilitating victims (NAPTIP, 2022). Its goal is combat-driven, focusing on stopping trafficking on all fronts. Amplifying the combative stance of "NAPTIP" is the keyword "Okah-donli", with keyness score of 513.786. Okah-Donli is the name of the then Director-General of NAPTIP who championed the fight against human trafficking on behalf of the Federal Government of Nigeria (FGN). The corpus is thus replete with this combat-like representation demonstrating the Nigerian government's collective fight against human trafficking. Other keywords which suggest this representation are: "fight", "war', "battle", "sensitisation", and "anti-trafficking". These words implicate battle rhetoric against human trafficking as captured in the following excerpts from the corpus:

Ex 1. … officials of the National Agency for the Prohibition of Trafficking in Persons, NAPTIP and others, said all hands must be on deck to fight the menace of human trafficking….
Ex 2. Okah-Donli has shown that Nigeria is indeed serious and committed to the war against trafficking in persons.
Ex 3. Mr. Nwachukwu said part of the new strategies was taking sensitisation campaigns against the crime to communities.
Ex 4. … the Edo State government passed a new anti-trafficking law and provided additional resources to combat trafficking, while Delta and Ondo states established anti-trafficking task forces.
Ex 5. Government should increase funding for NAPTIP and their strategic partners to vigorously fight this battle.

Using dominantly the perspectivisation discursive strategy, Exs 1 to 5 expressly depict human trafficking as war. This war metaphoric positioning permeates the reporting style of the online news media to underscore the gravity of the act of trafficking in the country,

and justifies the coordinated actions against it by the FGN. The strategy basically describes the act as "menace" (Ex 1), "serious" (Ex 2), "crime" (Ex 3) and "battle" (Ex 5) to broadly assign a negative semantic orientation and attitude to the phenomenon. This orientation influences how readers perceive the act, the government and the offenders. More importantly, it creates the Us versus Them ideological polarisation demonstrated in the use of positive-representation of the FGN reported as fighting evil and negative Other-representation of traffickers presented as the evil being fought.

Other discursive strategies deployed in this combative representation are collectivisation, nominalisation, and intensification in their order of importance. All the excerpts deploy collectivisation to variously nominalise Nigeria(ns) as active agents in the war against human trafficking. Ex 1 uses the discursive sub-strategy of nominal inclusivity "all hands" to emphasise that the war must be fought by not just the officials of NAPTIP, but by all Nigerians. The use of the proper nouns "Okah-Donli" and "Nigeria" in Ex 2 typifies NAPTIP and the FGN, and depicts concerted efforts. Other nominals are "the Edo State government", "Delta and Ondo States", "anti-trafficking task forces", and "their strategic partners" used to assign agency roles to the collectivised groups. Significantly, the nominals implicitly construct positive in-group depiction of the collectivised groups as anti-human trafficking coalition in Nigeria. The positive portrayal demonstrates the rigorous fight against human trafficking in the country. This rigour is emphasised via the deployment of intensification lexemes "indeed" (in Ex 2), "additional" (in Ex 3) and "vigorously" (in Ex 5). "Indeed" is an adverbial used to amplify the veracity of the FGN's combative attitude against trafficking; "additional" is an adjective revealing the state government's added material support towards the campaign against trafficking, while "vigorously" is also an adverbial showing the push for more force and energy in the campaign. These intensifiers upgrade the illocutionary force of the war metaphor stance and positively qualify the collectivised sets as active agents in the war.

Girl-Child Prostitution and Forced Labour

Another prevalent construct in the representation of human trafficking in Nigerian online news media is girl-child prostitution and forced labour. Girl-child prostitution refers to the sexual exploitation of underage girls basically for financial gains. It captures modern sex slavery where young girls are trafficked for sexual gratification for willing sex service buyers who are predominantly men. This commercialisation of sex is what Osisanwo labels "commodification of sex" (2024, p. 10). Major words that mark this representation in the corpus are prostitution, commercial sex, asewo, madam, proceeds, one-round, short-time, all-night and burger. Prostitution and commercial sex are both synonyms referring to all practices of sexual activities carried out with the sole intent of financial purposes. *Asewo* is a Yoruba lexeme denoting prostitute or sex worker, while one-round, short-time and all-night all connote the types of sex rounds people engage in during sexual encounters. "Madam" and "burger" are words with pejorative semantic transfers. "Madam", a term of respect for an adult-woman, has its meaning shifted to a female manager of a sex trafficking ring who procures underage girls for commercial sex for her clients, while "burger" (a sandwich-like bun or roll) also generally connotes an adult female-trafficker. This finding affirms Suuntaus Project's (2015 as cited in Adeyinka, Lietaert & Derluyn, 2023, p. 3) revelation that girls trafficked for sex usually "live with

and work for a 'madam' who controls their lives and puts them to work on the streets where they solicit clients or, in other cases, they are locked in private homes and forced to attend to clients there." According to Adeyinka, Lietaert and Derluyn (2023), these madams are former trafficked-victims who have turned to top-traffickers who collude with other criminal networks to buy and sell girls for sexual exploitation. Excerpts 6 to 9 exemplify this representation in the corpus as presented below:

Ex 6: One of the victims, who spoke to PREMIUM TIMES, said many of the girls were from broken homes and sought a place to stay before they were lured into prostitution by the woman.

Ex 7: The girls were said to be trafficked to the hotel where they were kept and were being used to engage in commercial sex where the proceeds went to the "madam".

Ex 8: … She says she later understood that 'one-round' means having sex with a man once for the equivalent of N1,000 in Libya dinar, 'short-time' means three hours of sex for N3,000 equivalent, while 'all-night' means copulation from dusk to dawn for N6,000. "We both protested that we would not do 'asewo' (commercial sex work) and that our 'burger' (trafficker) only promised to get us housemaid jobs. The next five days was hell as the two of us were locked up in a room, without food and water, and constantly beaten up.

Ex 9: Chagala is a classic narrative of impoverished young African girls entangled in a web of slave trade, physical abuse, economic exploitation, ritual killing and sexual slavery in Egypt….

Perspectivisation is still a dominant discursive strategy in Exs 6 to 7 as it is used to demonstrate the online reporters' non-involvement and stance of neutrality in the news discourse. In achieving this, the use of reported speeches and nominal references are amply deployed. Exs 6 to 7 open with claim authentication, referencing the trafficked victims' claims through the use of nominal anaphora, "one of the girls" (Ex 6), "The girls" (Ex 7) and "She" (Ex 8). By referencing the victims' claims through reported speeches, their experiences are validated and the reality of trafficking girls for sexual exploitation is confirmed for readers' perception. The relative clause, "who spoke to PREMIUM TIMES" in Ex 6, is an intensification strategy meant to upgrade the veracity of the victims' narratives. The nominal "Chagala" in Ex 9 connotes a maidservant or a female domestic worker. The term aptly captures the objectification of women's bodies for sexual gratification or domestic labour exploitation. The trafficked victims' reported narratives are argumentation discursive strategy deployed to represent human traffickers as exploiters and deceivers, denounce human trafficking as illegal, and justify the legality of the war against human trafficking in Nigeria.

The preponderant use of the gender nominal "the girls" which Osisanwo (2024, p. 13) refers to as "classification identification", with its pro-forms "she", "they", "we" and "our", all collectivise the girl-child as the primary victim of human trafficking, thus assigning gender vulnerability to the collectivised group. Gender vulnerability conceptualises the susceptibility of individuals to various types of risks, harm, danger or

crises on the basis of their gender; hence, it is socially constitutive (Sreeremya, 2019). Generally, girl-victims of trafficking are far more than male-victims, thus corroborating previous research that there is a correlation between the prevalence of human trafficking and gender inequality as "71% of these victims are women and girls, making human trafficking a disproportionately gendered issue" (Sanders, 2025, p. 3). Gender vulnerability reflects predominantly in the corpus via the active verb "lure" that underscores the fact that girls are easy victims of deception occasioned by economic dependence, poverty, hardship, insurgence, limited education and job opportunities, family instability, etc. The consequent economic desperation for better opportunities usually makes these girls easy targets for traffickers who exploit their naivety and impoverishment to dehumanisee them, mostly in a country like Nigeria riddled with corruption and near-zero social protection for girls/women.

What Osisanwo (2024, p. 11) calls "descriptivisation", which gives detailed accounts of how the girls are sexually and exploitative dehumanised, also manifests in all the excerpts, mostly in Ex 7 that also deploys monetary quantification to scale up the girl-sex workers' earnings from N1,000 (for one-round of sex) to N6,000 (all-night sex). It becomes extreme modern sex slavery as these proceeds go to the "madam" (Ex 6) and non-compliance is met with stiff punishment for the girls (Ex 8). This reinforces the regime of sexual coercion that pervades human trafficking in Nigeria.

However, the girl-child is not the only victim of human trafficking, the boy-child is inclusive in the collective victims as seen in Exs 10 and 11. Using the numerical quantifying expressions "over 5,000" and "… out of about two million…" in Ex 10 to quantify NAPTIP's rescue efforts, the coordinated nominal "Nigerian young girls and boys" reveals gender-inclusivity in the representation of trafficking victimhood. Exs 10 captures both girls and boys as victims of sexual and forced labour trafficking, while Ex 11 assigns gender demarcation in the victims' trafficking experiences – domestic servitude/sex trafficking for girls, and forced labour, child begging and drug trafficking for boys. This demarcation upholds the traditional notion of gender dualism that entrenches gender inequality in most societies.

Ex 10: Over 5,000 out of about two million Nigerian young girls and boys trafficked within Nigeria and to various foreign countries for sexual exploitation and hard labour had so far been rescued by NAPTIP.

Ex 11: Girls in this connection are used as domestic servants or prostitutes while the boys are used as scavengers, beggars, car cleaners, bus conductors, drug peddlers and farm labourers in most locations.

Despite affirming gender inclusivity in trafficking victimhood, the girl-child's trafficking experiences gain more ground in the corpus than the boy-child's, as the frequency count of the keyword "girl" is 734 while that of "boy" is just 76. This suggests that sex trafficking and domestic servitude of girls are overemphasised in the corpus, while forced labour trafficking of boys are underemphasised. This corroborates Peter's (2015 cited in Sander, 2025) arguments that there exists a lopsided focus on sex trafficking of girls/women at the expense of labour trafficking of boys/men. This gendered asymmetry might tarnish

the anti-trafficking war rhetoric, and that could negatively impact trafficked victims' identification and rescue.

Parents' Complicity

One unique construct in the representation of human trafficking in the corpus is the victims' parents' complicity in their trafficking ordeals as demonstrated in Exs 12, 13 and 14.

Ex 12: Kano State Zonal Commandant of NAPTIP, Shehu Umar, said on Thursday that unfortunately 70 percent of the girls who were freed from forced labor or trafficking were taken away with the active consent of their parents.

Ex 13: "Parents must also stop mounting pressure on their children to travel out and endanger their lives so as to send money back home.
"Because of the family pressure, many of them end up as sex slaves in all sorts of dehumanizing conditions. If we get any of such parents, they will be prosecuted," he said.

Ex 14: Some victims' parents encourage them to obey their traffickers and endure exploitation to earn money.'

In incriminating the victims' parents in the act of trafficking, the nomination strategy is deployed to construct the noun phrases, "their parents" (Ex 12), "parents", "such parents" (Ex 13) and "some victims' parents" (Ex 14) as culpable social actors in their children's trafficking ordeal. The predication strategy is also simultaneously used to ascribe negative attributes to the parents in relation to giving "active consent" to the traffickers to traffick their children (Ex 12), "mounting pressure on their children to travel out … so as to send money back home" (Ex 13) and encouraging their trafficked children to "obey their traffickers and endure exploitation to earn money" (Ex 14). These negative attributes implicate the parents as trafficking-abettors and categorise them with the out-group traffickers. In authenticating the claims in the excerpts, perspectivisation is employed to underscore the online reporters' attitudinal positioning of non-involvement in the news discourse through the use of indirect speech (Exs 12 and 14) and quotation marks (Ex 13). Such a positioning makes evident positive representation of the trafficked victims as helpless children doing the bidding of their parents, and negative representation of the parents and traffickers as cruel adults. This also implicitly represents the discursive construction of Nigerian parents' vulnerability occasioned by poverty and economic hardship that may result in child neglect, maltreatment and children's lure to greener pastures abroad.

Juju Ritualism in Trafficking

Juju ritualism is another major construct frequently represented in the corpus. According to Adeyinka, Lietaert & Derluyn (2023), the Nigerian traffickers usually discreetly deploy juju rituals in which their victims are compelled to take oaths at designated shrines in Nigeria before they embark to their trafficking destinations. The oath-taking commits victims to total allegiance to their traffickers to keep their identities and locations secret,

and to pay any money demanded by the traffickers for the journey. Juju ritualism represented in the corpus is, therefore, trafficking oaths used as a form of fear exploitation to keep trafficked victims perpetually subservient to their traffickers. Keywords and expressions that discursively mark this representation in the corpus are rituals, oath taking, oath rituals, voodoo rituals, oath of secrecy, victim's urine ..., bonds, swear, spiritual, ritualist, spiritualist, etc., as exemplified in the following excerpts:

Ex 15: According to her, some rituals are performed on the victims where the potential victim's urine, pubic hair, finger nails, eye lashes, menstrual blood, underwear and other personal effects are collected.
She said that once these rituals were done, it would be seen as bond between the victims and traffickers.
"In spite of the rituals and oath taking, the victim reaches the destination point only to realize the farce behind the earlier sweet promises of a greener pasture.
"And in this circumstance, such person is told in strict terms not to renege on the oath of secrecy as it cannot be reversed," the NAPTIP DG said.

Ex 16: One woman claimed she was forced to pull the heart out of a chicken as part of the ritual in which they were forced to swear they would not try to escape or speak to gardaí once in Ireland or risk harm to themselves and their families.

Ex 17: Such victims are often made to undergo voodoo rituals forcing them to vow never to disclose their situation to the authorities.

In Exs 15, 16 and 17, the reporters employed the discursive strategy of nomination to categorise the victims and the traffickers into ingroup versus outgroup, respectively. The categorisation implicitly describes female-victims as the substantive casualties of juju rituals in trafficking, and depicts traffickers as the beneficiaries of those rituals. With this, the ingroup-victim versus outgroup offender dichotomous representation is projected in the news reports. Using further the strategy of predication, the victims' vulnerable attributes are intensified through the traffickers' negative attributes of deception and force, which are often simultaneously deployed to deliberately trick, convince and coerce these impoverished victims in taking and keeping the juju oaths.

In collaborating Osisanwo's (2024, p. 15-16) findings, this construct positively represents trafficked-victims as naïve, non-violent and defenceless individuals who are unaware of the actual intent of their traffickers. The traffickers are conversely represented negatively as callous, deceptive adults who use spirituality to defraud gullible Nigerians. Quotation marks are also used in the corpus to perspectivise the reports through the eyes of the trafficked-victims to make the narratives more real and deplorable. This deplorability cements Adeyinka, Lietaert and Derluyn's (2023, p. 4) findings that the juju rituals are "bad juju" with a scary oath-taking process where the victims' blood, pubic hair, nails or panties are collected as evidence of the spiritual bond between the parties involved. Among Nigerians, this juju ritual is regarded as black magic with the belief that grave consequences will befall those who violate the oaths; hence, its potency to perpetually enslave its victims.

Discussion of Findings

This study's discursive exploration of Nigerian Online news representation of human trafficking has unveiled four dominant constructs set within a polarised discourse of positive ingroup versus negative outgroup structure: combative stance, girl-child prostitution and forced labour, parents' complicity and juju ritualism. These four representations basically focus on the construct of social actors into ingroup versus outgroup categorisation. Major discursive strategies like perspectivisation, nomination, predication, intensification and argumentation are amply deployed in the construction, while sub-strategies like collectivisation, descriptivisation, identification and numeric quantification also play complementary roles in the representation. These findings bear some semblances with results from Osisanwo's, (2024) and Olajimbiti and Osisanwo's (2024) studies. The semblance demonstrates that news media and social media representations of human trafficking are somewhat akin.

Two collectivised sets of actors are delineated in the discourse representation, the human traffickers and the trafficked victims. The online news reporters negatively represent human traffickers, with their accomplices that include some of the victims' parents, as defrauders, economic exploiters, voodooists and cruel. Conversely, the trafficked-victims are represented as naïve, economically disadvantaged, vulnerable and endangered casualties of trafficking. This representation polarises the news discourse along the line of positive victim-ingroup and negative trafficker-outgroup depiction. This supports Koo's (2014) study on the dichotomous portrayal of victims and offenders of human trafficking in newspapers.

However, Lazar's (2007, p. 147) submission on "gender as an ideological structure" is significantly underscored in the online news representation of human trafficking as the keyword, word cloud and concordance analyses jointly reveal that girls are most at risk of human trafficking than boys. This gendered ideological structure demonstrates that there is a critical intersection between gender, culture and human trafficking in the Nigerian society. The discourse representation largely reveals the feminisation of human trafficking in which girls' bodies are objectified for sexual commodification, thus denying them of their agency and human dignity. This highlights the significant role of gender inequalities in the socio-cultural variables fuelling human trafficking globally, thus supporting Sander's (2025) empirical study on how gender inequality drives the human trafficking ring.

What is more interesting in the gender oppression is a reflection of how co-women operate within the Nigerian patriarchal culture to not just perpetuate, but institutionalise what Lazar (2007, p. 157) describes as "sexist attitudes and practices against other women." This is explicitly at work in the offensive "madam" appellation with their juju rituals that dominate the victims' narratives. The news discourse implicitly foregrounds women oppression against themselves within androcentric cultures. It could also be argued that the women's general vulnerable state has made former female victims of human trafficking turn into full-blown traffickers in a vicious cycle that has entrapped perpetually both victims and traffickers in the trafficking industry. Another gendered angle in the news discourse is the resultant overemphasis of sex trafficking of girls to the downplay of forced labour trafficking of boys. This portrays a selective attention on sex

trafficking which reinforces a gender bias against boys that are also often subjected to gruesome agricultural, construction, or domestic exploitations (Sander, 2025). This study thus predicates that these gender biases depict the critical role of gender in news media representation of human trafficking in Nigeria. With this, the critical connection between gender, news media and the discourse on human trafficking is brought to the fore.

Exploring these gender angles has significant implications for (re)shaping the social structures guiding the anti-trafficking war rhetoric, policymaking and awareness campaigns in Nigeria. As posited by Sander (2025, p. 24), gender inequality is the chief vulnerability factor influencing trafficked victims' individual experiences and fuelling unequal treatment in intervention strategies and legal support. The gender dynamic complexities driving human trafficking in Nigeria must be holistically addressed by the Nigerian government and NAPTIP. Inclusive structural reforms, economic empowerment and social support that reduce victims' vulnerabilities should be promoted. In agreement with extant studies (e.g., Osisanwo, 2024; Sander, 2025), NAPTIP should increase its collaboration with local, national and foreign agencies in intensive public awareness campaigns to (re) orientate Nigerians on the ills of trafficking, illegal migration, and the essence of protecting human dignity and moral values.

Conclusion

In conclusion, the discursive and gender constructs in Nigerian online news representation of human trafficking orient to a polarised ideological structure of positive victim-ingroup and negative trafficker-outgroup depiction that mirrors the gender biases being exploited by traffickers to prey on their victims. In expanding the literature on corpus linguistics, this study has demonstrated the role of corpus tools in interpreting online news discourse on human trafficking in Nigeria.

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